

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1992-11-26

To the bahá'ís of the world

1 A full century has gone by since the covenant of bahá'u'lláh was estab-
2 lished and set in motion. And we extend to the members of his community
3 our loving greetings as they are assembled today at the world congress in
4 New York and at auxiliary conferences on all continents, or as they other-
5 wise participate in the observance of this centennial occasion.
6 we are particularly pleased that we have been afforded a special opportu-
7 nity to pause for a moment, together with our fellow-believers, to gather our
thoughts, to see how we have fared since 1892, and to consider where we are now headed.
This enables us to engage in a symbolic act which by its very

nature exemplifies the purpose of the covenant—a covenant intended by

8 its divine Author to unite the races and nations of the earth.
9 Sublime emotions surge in our hearts as we survey the dramatic history
10 and amazing progress of these one hundred years. At the time of the passing
11 of bahá'u'lláh, the bahá'í community was contained within the borders of
12 no more than fifteen countries, the vast majority of its members living in his native
iran. The community now embraces the entire planet. we rejoice
13 at the spirit of unity which is evident in its steady consolidation through the
workings of the Administrative Order to which the covenant has given
14 birth. our cumulated experience has clearly demonstrated the efficacy of
15 the covenant. The genuine unity it induces greatly encourages our expecta-

tion that all of humanity can and will be united.144.9

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146 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

08we have toiled to build a community at a period when the world has

147 witnessed startling changes which have profoundly altered the character of
148 society and plunged it into an unprecedented state of worry and confusion.
149 indeed, the world in its current condition has lost its bearings through the
150 operation of forces it neither understands nor can control. it is a period
151 in which great dynasties and empires have collapsed in rapid succession,
152 in which powerful ideologies have captured the hearts of millions only to
153 expire in infamy, in which two world wars wreaked havoc on civilized life as it was
known at the beginning of the twentieth century.
154 in the wake of such horrendous disruptions, there have been unexampled
155 advances in the realms of science, technology and social organization; a veritable
explosion of knowledge; and an even more remarkable burgeoning in the awakening and
rise of masses of humanity which were previously
156 presumed to be dormant. These masses are claiming their rightful places

within the community of nations which has greatly expanded. with the

157 simultaneous development of communications at the speed of light and
transportation at the speed of sound, the world has contracted into a mere
158 neighborhood in which people are instantly aware of each other's affairs and
159 have immediate access to each other. And yet, even with such miraculous advances,
with the emergence of international organizations, and with val-iant attempts and brilliant
successes at international cooperation, nations

are at woeful odds with one another, people are convulsed by economic

160 upheavals, races feel more alienated than before and are filled with mistrust,
humiliation and fear.

161 collateral with these changes has been the breakdown of institutions,
162 religious and political, which traditionally functioned as the guideposts for the
stability of society. even the most resilient of these seem to be losing
163 their credibility as they have become preoccupied with their own internal
164 disorder. This calls attention to the emptiness of the moral landscape and
165 the feeling of futility deranging personal life. Thoughtful commentators write
apprehensively about the fall of culture and the consequent disap-pearance of values, the
loss of the fullness of the inner life, a technological
166 civilization facing an increasingly serious crisis. They write, moreover, of
167 the human species as being at the end with its wisdom and being unable to control
itself, of the need for divine wisdom and foresight, and of the

168 human psyche as being far removed from recognizing this need.

These ominous comments reflect the universal consequences of a failed

169 understanding as to the purpose of god for humankind. it is in this par-145.4

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146 1992–1993 • T h e h o l Y Y e a r

147 09ticular respect that the revelation of bahá'u'lláh sheds new light; it refreshes

148 our thoughts; it clarifies and expands our conceptions. his Teachings imbue

149 us with the abundance of god's love for his creatures; they impress upon

150 us the indispensability of justice in human relations and emphasize the im-

151 portance of adhering to principle in all matters; they inform us that human beings
have been created "to carry forward an ever-advancing civilization"

152 and that the virtues that befit the dignity of every person are: "forbear-

153 ance, mercy, compassion and loving-kindness towards all the peoples and kindreds
of the earth."

154 145-1

As the members of our community have pursued their plan for teaching

155 his faith, they have grown to appreciate more adequately the purpose of the

156 multifarious processes of change which have been at work during the course of the
century. "Such simultaneous processes of rise and fall, of integra-tion and of disintegration,
of order and chaos, with their continuous and reciprocal reactions on each other, are," our
Teachings tell us, "but aspects

157 of a greater plan, one and indivisible, whose Source is god, whose author is

158 bahá'u'lláh, the theatre of whose operations is the entire planet, and whose

159 ultimate objectives are the unity of the human race and the peace of all

mankind."

160 145-2

161 disunity is the crux of the problems which so severely afflict the planet.

162 it permeates attitudes in all departments of life. it is at the heart of all major

163 conflicts between nations and peoples. more serious still, disunity is com-

164 mon in the relations between religions and within religions, vitiating the very
spiritual and moral influence which it is their primary purpose to exert. "Should the lamp of

religion be obscured," bahá'u'lláh asserts, "chaos and

165 confusion will ensue, and the lights of fairness, of justice, of tranquility and peace
cease to shine."

166 145-3

in an elaboration of these dreadful consequences, our Teachings state

167 that "when, as a result of human perversity, the light of religion is quenched

168 in men's hearts . . . a deplorable decline in the fortunes of humanity im-

169 mediately sets in, bringing in its wake all the evils which a wayward soul is capable
of revealing. The perversion of human nature, the degradation of human conduct, the
corruption and dissolution of human institutions,

170 145-1. gwb, no. 109.2.

171 145-2. Adj, ¶101.145-3. Tb, p. 125.145.8

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146 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

147 10 reveal themselves, under such circumstances, in their worst and most revolt-

148 ing aspects. human character is debased, confidence is shaken, the nerves

149 of discipline are relaxed, the voice of human conscience is stilled, the sense of decency
and shame is obscured, conceptions of duty, of solidarity, of reciprocity and loyalty are
distorted, and the very feeling of peacefulness, of joy and of hope is gradually extinguished."

150 145-4

151 Such, unfortunately, is the state to which institutions and individuals

152 have come in our time. Against this background the requirements of the

153 covenant assume even more critical importance than before. There can be

154 no doubt that if our community is to cope with the situation, it must ad-vance rapidly
towards the next phase in its evolution. it will be a phase in

155 which the faith of bahá'u'lláh must of necessity anticipate a deep encounter

156 with the forces operating with such bewildering ferocity throughout the world. let us,
therefore, take this propitious occasion to review the cov-

157 enantal arrangement which generates and sustains our actions.

158 The foundation of our belief rests on our recognition of the sovereignty

of god, the unknowable essence, the Supreme creator, and on our sub-

159 mission to his will as revealed for this age by bahá'u'lláh. To accept the

messenger of god in his day and to abide by his bidding are the two

160 essential, inseparable duties which each soul was created to fulfill. one ex-
161 ercises these twin duties by one's own choice, and by so doing performs an act which
may be regarded as the highest expression of free will with which every human being is
endowed by an all-loving creator. The vehicle in this

162 resplendent age for the practical fulfillment of these duties is the covenant
163 of bahá'u'lláh. it is the instrument by which belief in him is translated into
164 constructive deeds.

165 The oneness of humankind is the pivotal principle and ultimate goal of
166 his mission. This principle means far more than the reawakening of the
167 spirit of brotherhood and goodwill among people: "i t implies an organic
168 change in the structure of present-day society, a change such as the world

has not yet experienced."

169 145-5 The covenant of bahá'u'lláh embodies the
170 spirit, instrumentality and method to attain this essential goal. in addi-

tion to laying down, in his book of laws, the fundamentals for a new

world order, bahá'u'lláh, in the book of his covenant, confirmed the

171 appointment of his Son 'Abdu'l-b ahá as the interpreter of his word and

172 145-4: wob, p. 187 .

173 145-5: wob, p. 43.145.11

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146 1992-1993 • T h e h o l Y Y e a r

147 11the center of his covenant. As the interpreter, 'Abdu'l-b ahá became the

148 living mouth of the book, the expounder of the word; as the center of the

covenant, he became the incorruptible medium for applying the word to

149 practical measures for the raising up of a new civilization. The covenant is,

150 therefore, unique as a divine phenomenon, in that bahá'u'lláh, further to

151 conferring upon 'Abdu'l-b ahá the necessary authority to fulfill the require-

152 ments of his singular office, vested in him the virtues of perfection in

153 personal and social behavior, that humanity may have an enduring model

154 to emulate. in no annals of the past is there recorded such an arrangement
155 for ensuring the realization of the purpose of the manifestation of god.

This covenant is the guarantee against schism; that is why those who

156 occasionally attempt to create a cleavage in the community utterly fail in the long
run. Similarly, the incessant persecution the community has been
157 forced to endure for more than a century in the land of bahá'u'lláh's birth
158 has not succeeded in destroying its identity or undermining its organic
159 unity. The glorious, ultimate effect of this arrangement will be to ensure the
establishment of the kingdom of god on earth, as promised in the holy
160 books of old and as proclaimed by bahá'u'lláh himself.

"The day of the promise is come," he clearly announces, "and he who

161 is the promised one loudly proclaimeth before all who are in heaven and all
162 who are on earth: ' verily there is none other god but he, the help in peril,
163 the Self-Subsisting!' i swear by god! That which had been enshrined from
164 eternity in the knowledge of god, the knower of the seen and unseen, is
165 revealed. happy is the eye that seeth, and the face that turneth towards, the

countenance of god, the lord of all being."

166 145-6

167 indeed, the coming of bahá'u'lláh ushered the world into a new age,
168 making possible the beginning of a wholly new relationship between hu-
169 manity and its Supreme creator. The characteristics of this relationship are
170 summed up in the covenant inaugurated upon his passing a century ago.
171 its spiritual dynamic and cohesive power, its unifying principles and practi-
172 cal institutional provisions are a pattern for the healing of the ills afflict-ing our
fractured societies and defective social systems. The covenant of

173 bahá'u'lláh gives new meaning to humanity's checkered history; it imparts a
174 fresh impulse to human striving. "like unto the artery," 'Abdu'l-bahá states,
175 it "beats and pulsates in the body of the world." The pervasive influence it

176 145-6. Adj, ¶108.145.14

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146 m e S S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e
147 12 exerts is at the heart of the derangement of human affairs; it drives the ac-
148 celerating transition from the old order to the new world order envisaged
149 by bahá'u'lláh. "Soon," he writes, "will the present day order be rolled
150 up, and a new one spread out in its stead." And he explains: "The world's
151 equilibrium hath been upset through the vibrating influence of this most
152 great, this new world order. mankind's ordered life hath been revolution-
153 ized through the agency of this unique, this wondrous System, the like of which
mortal eyes have never witnessed."

154 145-7

155 let those seriously concerned about the state and fate of the world give
156 due attention to the claims of bahá'u'lláh. let them realize that the storms
157 battering at the foundations of society will not be stilled unless and until spiritual
principles are actively engaged in the search for solutions to social problems. let us, the
followers of bahá'u'lláh, redouble our effort in the
158 exercise of our sacred duty to acquaint all humanity with the animating
159 purpose of the worldwide law of bahá'u'lláh. let them discover that, "far
160 from aiming at the subversion of the existing foundations of society, it seeks
161 to broaden its basis, to remold its institutions in a manner consonant with the needs
of an ever-changing world." let us, with patience and humility,
162 respond to challenging or skeptical questions while unfolding the purposes of this
law. let them know that it "can conflict with no legitimate alle-
163 giances, nor can it undermine essential loyalties. its purpose is neither to
164 stifle the flame of a sane and intelligent patriotism in men's hearts, nor to abolish the
system of national autonomy so essential if the evils of excessive centralization are to be
avoided."

165 145-8

166 let us by word and example show that "it does not ignore, nor does it at-
167 tempt to suppress, the diversity of ethnical origins, of climate, of history, of
168 language and tradition, of thought and habit, that differentiate the peoples
169 and nations of the world." finally, let them appreciate that "it calls for a
170 wider loyalty, for a larger aspiration than any that has animated the human race";
that "it insists upon the subordination of national impulses and inter-
171 ests to the imperative claims of a unified world"; that "it repudiates excessive

172 centralization on one hand, and disclaims all attempts at uniformity on the other”;
that “its watchword is unity in diversity.”

173 145-9

174 145-7 . gwb, nos. 4.2, 70.1.

175 145-8. wob, p. 41.145-9. wob, p. 41.145.17

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146 1992–1993 • T h e h o l Y Ye a r

147 It is especially noteworthy that coincidental with this bahá’í holy year

148 are the commemorations of other world-shaking occurrences which, centu-

149 ries ago, commenced processes destined to attain their glorious consumma-

150 tion in the promised day of god. The ultimate resolution of the profound

151 issues to which they gave rise, and which have ripened with the passage of time, is
discernible in the eventual realization of the world-embracing

152 System of b ahá’u’lláh.

153 our thoughts turn to the history of ‘Abdu’l-b ahá’s epic journey to the

154 west and particularly to North America where, in New york, he disclosed

155 to his western disciples the implications of the covenant of bahá’u’lláh. it

156 was, in a sense, an act of renewal, prospective of the consolidation of the

union of the old and New worlds into one global entity. Surnamed by

157 him “city of the covenant,” New york resonates with the effects of that

158 experience of eighty years ago.

159 145-10 Then it was still the major entryway to

160 the “land of promise” for millions of people seeking new horizons. Now it

161 is recognized as a gathering place for the leaders of nations, an international venue
for efforts at achieving unity in the political realm. its very atmo-

162 sphere vibrates with the hopes of a world seeking to set its affairs in order. Today, the
hearts of the bahá’ís throughout the earth are focused on this

163 city of the covenant wherein many thousands of their fellow-believers,

164 from all parts of the planet, have assembled in the second bahá’í world

165 congress. The presence there of such a widely varied representation of the human
race is an affirmation of the unific power of the covenant which the

166 event was convened to celebrate.

167 in this season of beginnings and of the commemorations of beginnings,
168 we bahá'ís set for ourselves a new measure of effort, one more daring and
persistent than before. may our words proclaim, and our deeds demon-
169 strate, that there is only one god, only one religion, only one race. And few
170 though we be, may we thus fulfill our duty towards bahá'u'lláh, towards his
171 covenant, and, indeed, towards all humankind.

172 145-10. gpb, p. 288.145.19

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146 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

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Success of the Second Bahá'í World Congress

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]